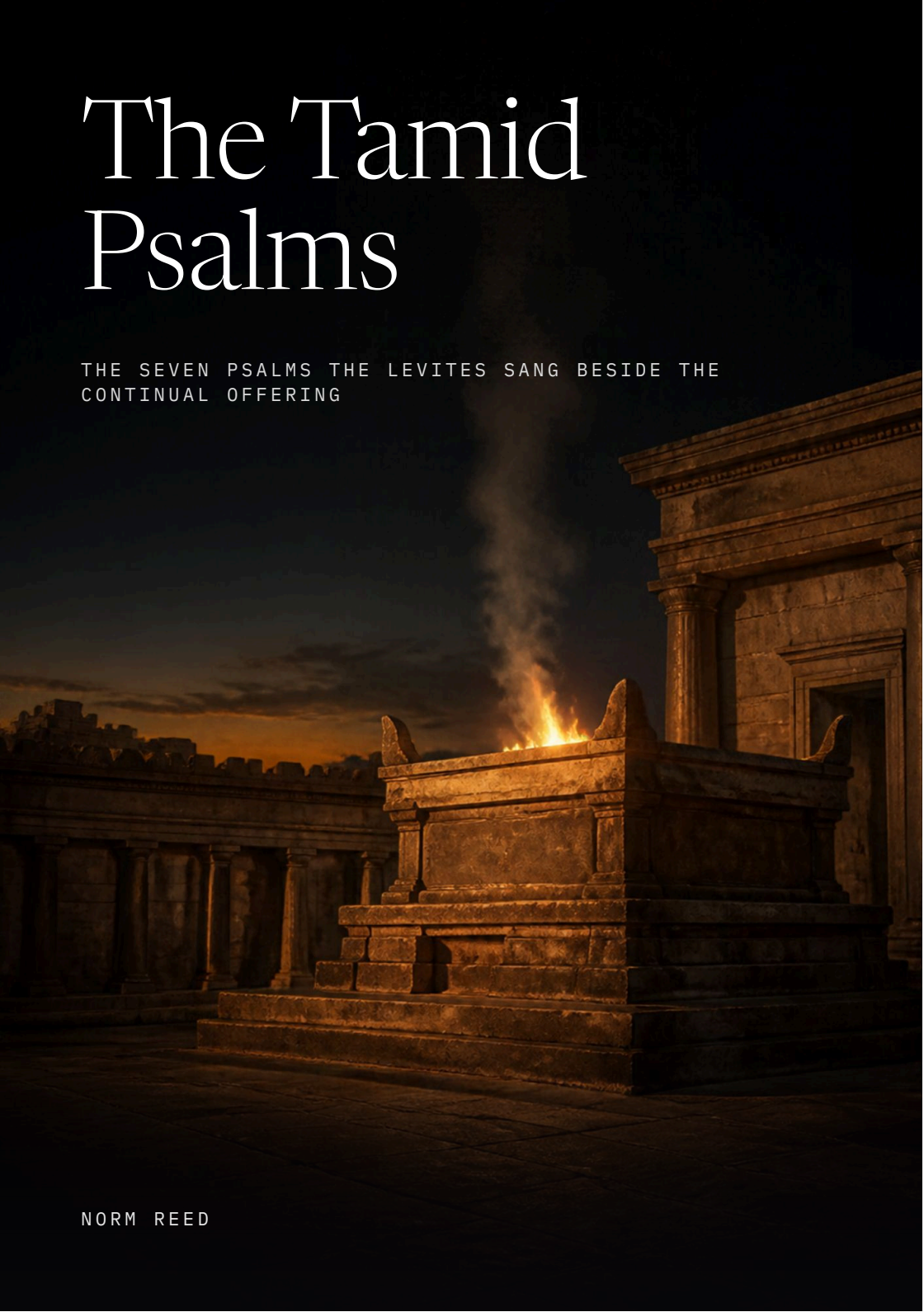
The Tamid Psalms

THE SEVEN PSALMS THE LEVITES SANG BESIDE THE CONTINUAL OFFERING



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The Tamid Psalms

The seven psalms the Levites sang beside the continual offering

FOR DAILY READING

THE CONTINUAL OFFERING

Twice each day, morning and evening, a lamb was offered in the Temple. It was called the *tamid* — the continual offering. Not a response to anything, not asked for by a crisis. It simply went up, every day, whether the nation was faithful or faithless.

While it burned, the Levites sang, and the Mishnah records which psalm belonged to which day. The rabbis explained the choice by mapping the week onto the days of creation: Sunday for the day God took possession of the world, Monday for the day he divided the waters, and so on to the Sabbath, which has no work behind it at all.

Here are those seven, one for each day, with a short note on why it sat where it did. Not a study guide — a pattern for reading. The same seven, week after week, until they are under your breath rather than in front of your eyes. That is what *tamid* means. Continual.

THE FIRST DAY

Sunday

Psalm 24

The Levites sang this on the first day because on the first day God took possession. Genesis opens with the world being made; Psalm 24 opens with the world being *owned* — the earth is Yahweh's, and everything in it. Sunday's psalm is not about beginnings in the sentimental sense. It is about title deed. Then it turns, and asks who may come up the hill — and the answer is not the strong or the qualified: clean hands, a heart undivided. And then the gates are told to lift their heads, because the King of glory is coming in. The Hebrew is *kavod*: weight, the heft of a presence that bears down on a room. The day begins by settling whose world it is, and ends by letting the weight of him through the door.

1 The earth is Yahweh's, with its fullness;
the world, and those who dwell therein.

2 For he has founded it on the seas,
and established it on the floods.

3 Who may ascend to Yahweh's hill?
Who may stand in his holy place?

4 He who has clean hands and a pure heart;
who has not lifted up his soul to falsehood,
and has not sworn deceitfully.

5 He shall receive a blessing from Yahweh,
righteousness from the God of his salvation.

6 This is the generation of those who seek
Him, who seek your face—even Jacob.
Selah.

7 Lift up your heads, you gates!
Be lifted up, you everlasting doors, and the
King of glory will come in.

8 Who is the King of glory?
Yahweh strong and mighty, Yahweh mighty
in battle.

9 Lift up your heads, you gates;
yes, lift them up, you everlasting doors, and
the King of glory will come in.

10 Who is this King of glory?
Yahweh of Armies is the King of glory!
Selah.

THE SECOND DAY

Monday

Psalm 48

The second day divided the waters above from the waters below, and God ruled over what he had parted. So Monday's psalm is about a city with a mountain in the middle of it, and kings who came, looked, and fled. It is the psalm for the day you have to hold a line. Walk about Zion, it says. Count her towers. Mark her ramparts — not to admire them, but so that you can tell the next generation what it looked like when God was the defence.

1 Great is Yahweh, and greatly to be praised,
in the city of our God, in his holy mountain.

2 Beautiful in elevation, the joy of the whole earth,
is Mount Zion, on the north sides, the city of the great King.

3 God has shown himself in her citadels as a refuge.

4 For, behold, the kings assembled themselves,
they passed by together.

5 They saw it, then they were amazed.
They were dismayed.
They hurried away.

6 Trembling took hold of them there,
pain, as of a woman in travail.

7 With the east wind, you break the ships of
Tarshish.

8 As we have heard, so we have seen, in the
city of Yahweh of Armies, in the city of our
God.
God will establish it forever.
Selah.

9 We have thought about your loving kindness,
God, in the middle of your temple.

10 As is your name, God, so is your praise to
the ends of the earth.
Your right hand is full of righteousness.

11 Let Mount Zion be glad!
Let the daughters of Judah rejoice, because
of your judgments.

12 Walk about Zion, and go around her.
Number its towers.

13 Mark well her bulwarks.
Consider her palaces, that you may tell it to
the next generation.

14 For this God is our God forever and ever.
He will be our guide even to death.

THE THIRD DAY

Tuesday

Psalm 82

On the third day the dry land appeared — and with it a place where justice could stand. The psalm puts God in the middle of the council of the powerful and asks them how long they will judge crookedly. Then the charge: defend the weak and the fatherless, maintain the rights of the poor. It ends with them dying like men. Tuesday is the day the psalter asks what you have done with the authority you were given.

1 God presides in the great assembly.
He judges among the gods.

2 “How long will you judge unjustly,
and show partiality to the wicked?” Selah.

3 “Defend the weak, the poor, and the
fatherless.
Maintain the rights of the poor and
oppressed.

4 Rescue the weak and needy.
Deliver them out of the hand of the
wicked.”

5 They don't know, neither do they understand.
They walk back and forth in darkness.
All the foundations of the earth are shaken.

6 I said, “You are gods, all of you are sons of
the Most High.

7 Nevertheless you shall die like men,
and fall like one of the rulers.”

8 Arise, God, judge the earth,
for you inherit all of the nations.

THE FOURTH DAY

Wednesday

Psalm 94

The fourth day hung the sun and the moon, which is why the psalm for it speaks against those who would worship what God merely made. It is the angriest of the seven and the most useful. How long will the wicked triumph. It insists that the God who made the ear can hear and the God who formed the eye can see — and then, quietly, that he knows the thoughts of men, that they are *hevel*: breath, vapour, gone. Midweek is where people break. This psalm does not tell you it is fine. It tells you who is counting.

1 Yahweh, you God to whom vengeance belongs,
you God to whom vengeance belongs, shine out.

2 Rise up, you judge of the earth.
Pay back the proud what they deserve.

3 Yahweh, how long will the wicked,
how long will the wicked triumph?

4 They pour out arrogant words.
All the evildoers boast.

5 They break your people in pieces,
Yahweh, and afflict your heritage.

6 They kill the widow and the alien,
and murder the fatherless.

7 They say, “Yah will not see,
neither will Jacob's God consider.”

8 Consider, you senseless among the people;
you fools, when will you be wise?

9 He who implanted the ear, won't he hear?
He who formed the eye, won't he see?

10 He who disciplines the nations, won't he
punish?
He who teaches man knows.

11 Yahweh knows the thoughts of man,
that they are futile.

12 Blessed is the man whom you discipline,
Yah, and teach out of your law;

13 that you may give him rest from the days of
adversity,
until the pit is dug for the wicked.

14 For Yahweh won't reject his people,
neither will he forsake his inheritance.

15 For judgment will return to righteousness.
All the upright in heart shall follow it.

16 Who will rise up for me against the wicked?
Who will stand up for me against the
evildoers?

17 Unless Yahweh had been my help,
my soul would have soon lived in silence.

18 When I said, “My foot is slipping!” Your
loving kindness, Yahweh, held me up.

19 In the multitude of my thoughts within me,
your comforts delight my soul.

20 Shall the throne of wickedness have
fellowship with you,
which brings about mischief by statute?

21 They gather themselves together against the
soul of the righteous,
and condemn the innocent blood.

22 But Yahweh has been my high tower,
my God, the rock of my refuge.

23 He has brought on them their own iniquity,
and will cut them off in their own
wickedness.
Yahweh, our God, will cut them off.

THE FIFTH DAY

Thursday

Psalm 81

The fifth day filled sea and sky with living things that sing, so Thursday begins with noise: sing aloud, raise a song, bring the tambourine. Then it changes voice and God himself speaks — I removed the burden from his shoulder, and you would not listen. The psalm's grief is that the table was set and they would not eat: open your mouth wide, and I will fill it. It is a day for remembering that a good deal of what we call scarcity is refusal.

1 Sing aloud to God, our strength!
Make a joyful shout to the God of Jacob!

2 Raise a song, and bring here the tambourine,
the pleasant lyre with the harp.

3 Blow the trumpet at the New Moon,
at the full moon, on our feast day.

4 For it is a statute for Israel,
an ordinance of the God of Jacob.

5 He appointed it in Joseph for a testimony,
when he went out over the land of Egypt, I

heard a language that I didn't know.

6 “I removed his shoulder from the burden.
His hands were freed from the basket.

7 You called in trouble, and I delivered you.
I answered you in the secret place of
thunder.
I tested you at the waters of Meribah.”
Selah.

8 “Hear, my people, and I will testify to you,
Israel, if you would listen to me!

9 There shall be no strange god in you,
neither shall you worship any foreign god.

10 I am Yahweh, your God, who brought you up
out of the land of Egypt.
Open your mouth wide, and I will fill it.

11 But my people didn't listen to my voice.
Israel desired none of me.

12 So I let them go after the stubbornness of
their hearts,
that they might walk in their own counsels.

13 Oh that my people would listen to me,
that Israel would walk in my ways!

14 I would soon subdue their enemies,
and turn my hand against their adversaries.

15 The haters of Yahweh would cringe before
him,
and their punishment would last forever.

16 But he would have also fed them with the
finest of the wheat.
I will satisfy you with honey out of the
rock.”

THE SIXTH DAY

Friday

Psalm 93

The sixth day finished the work, and the psalm for it is the shortest of the seven because there is nothing left to add. Yahweh reigns; he is clothed with majesty. The floods lift up their voice — and above them, higher, he is. Five verses, and the last turns to the house: holiness adorns your house, forever. Friday is where the week is handed over.

1 Yahweh reigns!
He is clothed with majesty!
Yahweh is armed with strength.
The world also is established.
It can't be moved.

2 Your throne is established from long ago.
You are from everlasting.

3 The floods have lifted up, Yahweh, the floods
have lifted up their voice.
The floods lift up their waves.

4 Above the voices of many waters,
the mighty breakers of the sea, Yahweh on

high is mighty.

5 Your statutes stand firm.
Holiness adorns your house, Yahweh,
forever more.

THE SEVENTH DAY

Sabbath

Psalm 92

The only psalm in the psalter titled for the Sabbath, and the only day of the seven with no work behind it. It is a good thing to give thanks, it begins — and then sets two pictures side by side: the wicked springing up like grass, and the righteous growing like a cedar in Lebanon, still bearing fruit in old age, full of sap and green. Grass and cedar differ in one thing only. Where they are planted. The Sabbath psalm does not ask you to do anything. It asks where you are rooted.

1 It is a good thing to give thanks to Yahweh,
to sing praises to your name, Most High;

2 to proclaim your loving kindness in the morning,
and your faithfulness every night,

3 with the ten-stringed lute,
with the harp, and with the melody of the lyre.

4 For you, Yahweh, have made me glad
through your work.

I will triumph in the works of your hands.

5 How great are your works, Yahweh!
Your thoughts are very deep.

6 A senseless man doesn't know,
neither does a fool understand this:

7 though the wicked spring up as the grass,
and all the evildoers flourish, they will be
destroyed forever.

8 But you, Yahweh, are on high forever more.

9 For, behold, your enemies, Yahweh, for,
behold, your enemies shall perish.
All the evildoers will be scattered.

10 But you have exalted my horn like that of
the wild ox.
I am anointed with fresh oil.

11 My eye has also seen my enemies.
My ears have heard of the wicked enemies
who rise up against me.

12 The righteous shall flourish like the palm
tree.

He will grow like a cedar in Lebanon.

13 They are planted in Yahweh's house.
They will flourish in our God's courts.

14 They will still produce fruit in old age.
They will be full of sap and green,

15 to show that Yahweh is upright.
He is my rock, and there is no
unrighteousness in him.

TAMID

The tamid was the offering nobody noticed. The festivals drew crowds; the great sacrifices were occasions. The continual offering was just there, morning and evening, year after year, and its significance was precisely that it did not depend on anyone feeling anything.

Most of what holds a life together works the same way. Not the occasions. The continual thing, done again on the day you cannot see the point of it.

These seven psalms are not a programme to complete. They are a rhythm to return to. Read Sunday's psalm on Sunday. Next Sunday, read it again.

The text is the World English Bible, which is in the public domain and renders the divine name as Yahweh rather than THE LORD.